

Week 11 Assignment | Ethical Issues Analysis

Part I

If I download a textbook I accidentally find, I would be violating an intellectual property rights (aka copyright infringement) even if my intentions are academic. Authors and/or publishers should get fair compensation for the work and effort they put. And my so called unintentional discovery does not justify my act of downloading the stuff and use it for free although it reduces my intent. I mean, I like free tools and “things”; who doesn’t? But that doesn’t mean I should be cutting off other’s living. That’s just not fair.

If I intentionally search from a site that advertises popular textbooks for free, it is straight away an intentional piracy rather than an accidental discovery. I am looking for FREE stuffs deliberately, meaning clearer violation of ethical and legal responsibility. This also means that I would be less defensible ethically, just because I am actively participating in and supporting copyright theft. But on the other hand, we could look at the fact that the site is “advertising”. Now I am not sure if it is doing so illegally according to the context, but to be open minded, I would argue that if the site itself is advertising with the author’s content, then it would not pose an ethical issue and this whole analysis wouldn’t matter much. But if it was other way around, then yeah, I along with site’s administrators are in the same path of infringement.

If instead of just showing the questions in the exercise at the end of each chapter, the copy I find has all the answers, too, and I notice that my professor draws all exam questions from the exercises, I would panic and be excited at the same time to be honest. As I panic and get excited, ethical issues would escalate further as it involves academic dishonesty in addition to copyright violation, violates fairness and integrity while undermining learning and institutional trust. But wait a minute! My professor’s doing the same too. So isn’t it supposed to be completely fine? Well it depends actually. We don’t know if the professor has crossed any ethical lines while doing so. My professor could have bounded with the ethical guidelines, bought the contents, and used it to instruct his students. That’s totally fine, it’s not cheating or a theft. But if it was other way around and I go down, then my professor’s going down with me because we both are guilty of our poor actions.

Part II

If I tell the owner what I have found, it actually depends what ethical implications shall be. For example: If I was illegally connected to the network and/or performed the scan, then for sure I would have to answer to the owner's questions "What in the world are you doing on my network?", "Are you spying on me?", and other few threatening and mind tampering questions and statements. As for ethical implications of this action, it is severe. But If I was legally and rightfully connected to the network and did what I did, then my ethics would generally be accepted as responsible and respectful. Of course I wouldn't disclose it to other than the owner at first, but overall implications would be good in this scenario.

Telling my local administrator or security officer what I have found is what I consider as best practice option in most organization contexts. Because it routes the issue to people with authority and process to fix it and reduces risk of mishandling. Also, we would have to look at the fact if I deduced the owner's identity through intrusive means, then I should disclose how I found it so the admin can judge privacy/legal implications. So to conclude the ethical implications for this scenario, it would be on my side and right actions shall be taken against the discovered issue.

Exploiting a minor vulnerability to show the owner how serious it is, is kind of a risky approach. Even so called minor exploitation is unauthorized access and may be illegal, can damage systems or data and can breach trust as well. Thus, such demonstrations should only be done with explicit, written permission. Without such an authorization, this is ethically and legally unsound even though the owner could be "completely cool" about the whole thing.

Exploiting a minor vulnerability as a prank without telling the owner is clearly an unethical and irresponsible approach. It intentionally harms trust, may disrupt operations, and likely violates law and policy. Such pranks can have real consequences such as data loss, disciplinary action, legal trouble, and so on. Thus, it should be avoided and reporting any finding must be done instead.

Telling the owner and then demand money for details is what we call an extortion. It is criminal, entirely unethical, and destroys professional credibility. It should be kept in mind that even bug bounty style demands must go through formal programs with prior authorization. And demanding money in this scenario's way is absolutely not a way to do it. It is like stealing a car and demanding money to return it.

Using a vulnerability to take control, patch it, and never tell anyone is also an unauthorized access regardless of my well intention. It just bypasses consent, breaks chain of custody, risks unintended side effects and removes the owner's right to know. Plus, I can unintentionally introduce bugs and/or configuration issues and/or be blamed for any changes or the main cause of the root issue itself. It should be kept in mind that transparency and authorization are required for remediation actions.